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Ray Vega

Ray Vega enjoys a productive career in jazz as a dynamic soloist, valued sideman, and prolific composer. He is a member of the music faculty at the University of Vermont and was recognized in 2015 with a University Scholar Award.

Ray was interviewed via Zoom on July 20, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Ray Vega with me this morning. You are now a — let me find your quote — a Vermonterican?

RV: Yeah. See I'm of the generation of first generation-born of New Yorkers to Puerto Rican parents so we probably call ourselves the Nuyoricans. But after moving to Vermont, now 15 years in Vermont, that's my new moniker — the Vermonterican.

MR: When you were a kid, was there a distinction between young men and women born in Puerto Rico and those whose parents were born but came to —

RV: I always found it interesting where in New York City they would say, "Hey, there's that Spanish kid, there's that Puerto Rican kid." Then I go to Puerto Rico and family members will go, "There's Ralph's son the American." You know so it was always very confusing. But you know my parents were of the generation that came in in the 1940s, the latter part of the 40s, early 50s. And so when we were being raised in the projects we lived in predominantly African-American community in the projects in the South Bronx and you know you heard all the music and the culture of 1960s New York, 1970s New York. But when you entered our house, our apartment in the projects, you may as well have been in Puerto Rico you know, the smells of the food, just a different energy and all that. And so we were raised up always calling ourselves Puerto Rican, never calling ourselves anything but. It was like we're Puerto Ricans, we — it was just very clear to us. My parents were very proud of their heritage. So you know you think about the first generation of kids born into like this thing and so we're speaking Spanish to our parents at home but then English to everybody else. And I think it was kind of neat, a lot of things continued like the food traditions, music traditions. That's usually how it is with first generation perhaps, because my two kids right now, my three kids right now don't speak any Spanish. And their mother is Puerto Rican like I am, Nuyorican, the same thing. So currently in Vermont we're probably — my wife and my three kids and my two dogs, we're seven Vermontericans among maybe I don't know, maybe a hundred in the state.

MR: Dave Valentin, when I interviewed him, he said, this is a quote, he said, "My parents are from Puerto Rico, they migrated to New York and settled in the original South Bronx. It was a wonderful New York neighborhood, a mixed neighborhood, Italian, Jews, Greeks and Puerto Ricans, and a whole true community where there was really no problem getting along at all." And he said, "I think they brought the old values into the community: be nice and do the right thing."

RV: Yeah. That's how it was when I was growing up. And mind you we were in the Mott Haven which is one of the poorest parts of the poorest Congressional district in the United States. But when we were coming up the parents, the parents that moved their families into the projects, the projects were the next step up from living in the tenements. But one of our neighbors, which I didn't find out until many, many years later, one of our neighbors was the Fleet family. And I always knew the Fleet family, you know they were all well-dressed people, and then it wasn't until I was living in Vermont and I made mention on social media that I was speaking to my jazz history class about Biddy Fleet, who was the guitarist that worked with Charlie Parker and then the son James Fleet contacts me and he tells me, "Ray, I've never told you this but that's my father." And he was living in the projects with us. They were living in the projects. I think Biddy wanted to continue — I think he continued a job as some kind of a social — he had like a government job, usually postal work probably, something to that effect. But that's what stopped him from going on the road and continuing playing music full time. But the son, James, I went to high school with, he went to elementary school, middle school, and high school with my brother Julio. All the grades. And he's a visual artist like my brother, but he also plays saxophone. But these were the types of families that were living in the projects at the time. They were, the projects were supposed to be a step up from the tenements of Harlem, the tenements of places like Williamsburg, Brooklyn or where my parents moved in from which was in East Harlem which they called The Barrio. So moving to the projects was like a big, big move up. Plus my building had 13 floors or has — the building's still there — has 13 floors and eight apartments per floor. And I could tell you that as a kid growing up I could probably identify every family in the building. We all knew each other. And people looked out for each other. And it was a hodgepodge of — there was people from African-American background, people whose families came up during the great migration of the latter part of the teens of the twentieth century, there were folks that came in from Puerto Rico, some folks from the Dominican Republic, folks from the Caribbean like Jamaica. I remember there was a white family that lived upstairs and he was a cop. His name was Carl and we knew him. We knew him, he was a cop, he was a cop. He was a beat cop, he had his uniform, and he was living in the

this guy Carl lived in the projects and we all knew him and the kids went to school in our neighborhood. It's interesting.

MR: Were they tolerant of your trumpet practicing?

RV: You know what it was? Those walls were so thick in those buildings that you could hear it in the apartment but you know I would practice with a mute in. I kept it pretty controlled.

MR: Okay.

RV: I kept it pretty controlled. Also you know I don't think that I really developed my serious practice regimen until I was already an adult and out of the projects. Because you know you're young and, you're just young and —

MR: You want to play stickball instead?

RV: You want to hang out, you want to play, you've got your girlfriend. You're listening to records. You don't know how to practice. And it wasn't until I found some really great teachers in the mid-1980s. It really helped me to kind of focus, how to practice and how to work on things. And you know one was a harmony teacher named Susan Winder, another one was Henry Novak who played trumpet with the New York City Ballet, and then for a short period this guy named Lonnie Hillyer who played with Charles Mingus's band, and then I studied with one of Barry Harris's students, a guy named Bob Regoven. So these folks really kind of showed me how to like organize my thoughts. You know you might hear some crying back here, those are my puppies. But yeah, now so the trumpet in the projects wasn't really an issue. Especially, I grew up in the projects so people, this was at the time where people were discovering disco music so they would blast music outside of their windows, which was a real drag.

MR: I was going to ask you about that. You were born in 1961 is that correct?

RV: Yes.

MR: So I picked sort of an arbitrary time, 1975 you would have been around 14 and I looked at the top songs. 1975. Number 1 — "Love Will Keep Us Together" by Captain & Tennille.

RV: Captain & Tennille, I remember that pop radio.

MR: Number 2 — "Rhinestone Cowboy" by —

RV: Keep going.

MR: And down at Number 22 was "The Hustle."

RV: Oh yeah. I grew up listening to all that music. Well hearing it. I was hearing it in the background 'cause I had family members that really loved that stuff. But at that time, in 1975, I was at the time, I started out at the High School of Music & Art. I was a freshman at that time, and I was discovering Charlie Parker and Dizzy and Freddie Hubbard. That's

wonderful recordings like there's a recording of the Philadelphia, New York, and I want to say Chicago Symphony brass sections playing the Gabrieli Canzon. It was a very famous recording that was put out by I want to say RCA. And I had a really good trumpet teacher in high school named Sidney Baker who was from that tradition. So you just, when you're around it that's what you know. And mind you, this is before the Internet. So if you wanted to really seek out information you had to really put some — you had to make a real effort. You have to make a real effort. Sorry, my dog just moved this. Stay there. Sorry about that, Monk.

MR: It's okay, we are doing home studio today.

RV: Yes.

MR: When did the idea, I mean you're playing a single note instrument. Do you remember around what age you were when you started to be curious and understand about how single notes match up with chord symbols, and how chord symbols work?

RV: Okay so my thing is this. And I share this openly with my students and I let them know, don't be scared. I am the poster child for dyslexia. So the whole idea of the note and how it matches up to a chord, that was a nightmare for me. I knew what the note sounded like, and I could hear the chords, but making the match of the mathematics was a very major challenge for me. So I could play on "Rhythm" changes, I could play "Rhythm" changes, I could do standards, because I had really good ears, before I figured out what a 2-5-1 progression was. I could hear it. Gary Bartz said something really interesting to me. He told me, "You know, your brain might be dyslexic but your ears aren't. So, because getting the math of the music, the technical aspects, that was a challenge for me. That was a huge challenge for me. And I share that with my students so that they feel encouraged to allow their ears to be a helpful guide in what they're doing. So yeah, I mean I studied harmony and I studied with some great jazz people but it was a very challenging process for me. So I'll put it to you this way, I loved what Bird was playing but I couldn't understand it. I would sit there and go whoa — like listening to — all right Bird and Dizzy Gillespie. I remember the first time I heard "Things to Come," Dizzy Gillespie's big band, it was from an LP that I picked up around 1975-'76, and I couldn't figure out what the hell was going on. It was incredibly modern and it blew my mind. And I was like this is amazing. And then I remembered going to see Dizzy down at Henry Street Settlement in New York and he had a band that was kind of playing funky at the time he had the electric bass and Mickey Roker was playing drums kind of in a funky style, but Dizzy was playing bebop. And I could hear it. It was just like wow. I remember at that same time I was given tickets to — the gentlemen that runs the, he was one of the top guys at the High School of Music & Art, he gave me some tickets to go see

Baroque and Renaissance music. So I remember sitting there and there was this woman dressed up all beautifully and she's playing the harpsichord, and I say, in my ignorant South Bronx fashion, I go, "Hey man, that's bebop." Because I could hear [scats] and I went, "Oh man that's bebop." You know. Because listen, when I was in high school my girlfriend at the time, her father was a jazz guitar player, Doc Russell. And he took an interest in my development and they would have jam sessions at the house and I would go there with my trumpet, with my ears, you know, with my ears, and I would learn these tunes that they were playing by ear. Is the barking affecting the conversation right now?

MR: Yeah.

RV: Yeah? Okay. Let me do something very quick. Can we pause for one second?

MR: I can pause, yep.

RV: Thank you.

MR: Well with all that in mind, your ear learning and your ability to play well and fit into the music, does this have ramifications for how you teach your students?

RV: Oh yeah.

MR: I've had students who come to me with things they've learned from other teachers or perhaps on the Internet and they ask about certain harmonic things that I never use. And so I'm wondering how to deal with that?

RV: Well what happens is these kids are also getting on the Internet and getting tons of information and getting there's — I think it's sensory overload, the amount of information that they can get. So I slow them down and I just tell them okay, let's slow down and I let them know, you know, you're going to have to learn how to play by ear. You're going to have to. I tell them you've got to learn all these scales, you're going to learn all these patterns, you're going to get the sound of this under your fingers. When it comes down to you playing the music, if you can't immerse yourself in the sound of the music and allow yourself to play, you're not really playing. I remember a conversation I had with Freddie Hubbard where Freddie tells me, he tells me, Freddie was funny, he'd go, "Ray, they're asking me why did I play such-and-such a thing on such-and-such a chord on "One Finger Snap." And he goes, "Man at that time we were playing by ear." And I figured, and I didn't question him about that, I just listened to him and I went of course they were because they were first of all, these guys were a community of players in New York. They were living in New York at the time, a lot of them. So they were a community of players, so think about who his contemporaries were at the time that he was hanging out with. He was hanging out with Coltrane, he was hanging out with Eric Dolphy, he was hanging out with James Spaulding, Joe Henderson, those are just some of the saxophone players, Wayne Shorter, Cedar Walton, McCoy Tyner, Herbie, and on and

together for these Blue Note sessions which they really just — these were not working bands. They got together, looked at the music and went in. But at that point they were speaking to each other in such a highly sophisticated fashion that they could hear through things. They could hear through things. So what I tell the students is I tell them you're not going to be able to play freely if all you're going to have is that piece of music in front of you and looking at the chord progressions to figure out what you need to play against. You've got to get to the point where you hear what the changes are. Because that's what I learned from playing by ear. I can go to a jam session and they could be playing "All the Things You Are" and I knew exactly where they were at every given moment. I wasn't going to be able to recite the chord progressions to you but I could hear where they were and I could hear the melody. But that was the whole thing with Doc Russell's — we would go out and do gigs and by the time, you know maybe five or six months into my hanging out with them I learned like 30, 35 tunes all by ear, that I would play with his band. And of course I was young, I was a young kid so I was going to sound like a young kid, but they never once mentioned one chord progression to me. They never did that. It was just like check it out, listen to it. And one of the guys that was playing with Doc that would come to play many times with Doc was James Spaulding. James Spaulding from Indianapolis of the fame of the Freddie Hubbard's group, played with McCoy Tyner, played with all these great recordings on Blue Note Records. But Spaulding would be there and they'd just go, "Yeah, try it again, try it again, try it again." He never sat there, "Hey man that's a minor 2-5 and you've got to play this." He didn't do that. Don't get me wrong, I think it's important to learn the mathematics of it, but I think a lot of kids, the biggest problem with what a lot of kids are doing is that they're trying to play this music by learning the math about it but they're not really immersing themselves in the actual music. They're not listening to the recordings. This is part of my discussion in my Jazz History classes. I walk in front and I pull out my thing and I go, "This is the problem, folks. Everybody here has 5,000 tunes on them and they listen to the first 20 seconds of one tune and they go to another one, and nobody's listening to music from the beginning to the end and of course now with the shuffle option that you have in playing music, you're not even listening to a recording from beginning to end. You know? You put down "Blues and the Abstract Truth" Oliver Nelson. Let it play through. Turn it over. Let it play through, turn it over again. And that's how we immersed ourselves in the sound of the music around us. Also I think another thing that's a big issue with how people are internalizing the music is that we're no longer sitting at someone's home with a beautiful stereo system going hey, I remember in high school a trombonist, now he's a saxophonist Pablo Carey tells me, "I got the new Dexter Gordon

remember going down to 24th Street and they had an interesting loft apartment, it was a great apartment. I remember getting up there and he had like an old school stereo system, you know a real nice sounding stereo, and he'd put that recording on of Dexter Gordon's "Sophisticated Giant" and we just sat there, Pablo and myself I think. Pablo Carey teaches in Maine. Another one of our buds in those circles was David Glasser who plays lead alto with the Basie band. So we'd be sitting there going oh wow, and internalizing the music. Now those guys were geniuses because they understood all the harmony. So my dyslexia was just like rampant but it did not stop me from falling in love with the sound of the music, but what I'm saying is this is the issue that I have with this thing called jazz education is that we're teaching these kids all of this math without first playing a bunch of recordings of the blues and listening, and just take that in and listen to it. Because we're putting the cart before the horse. We're learning all of this math but then these kids can't play by ear. I'll have these kids that can play triad patterns and do all of this stuff and I'll go up to them and I'll go [scats] and they're going — they can't do it. That's a problem.

MR: I've insisted that there's a magic to improvisation, to jazz improvisation that's not really explainable but that is a problem I think in the world of education because you can't teach a four year program on jazz without getting into the codifying of it. I mean how are you going to adjust —

RV: How do you apply it? Well codifying, how do you explain it all, and how do you put it into words? The problem here I would say is that many of the academics that are coming out here right now understand the math of it but they've never put a set list together in Europe trying to figure out who — well the heck with Europe, I've done that enough times, I'm talking about they haven't even done a local gig looking into the audience and going okay we've got to play this, let's try this, let's read the audience. Instead they've got to go in there and just going to play their stuff, and play all the patterns and everything that they learned, but there's a major disconnect, there's a huge disconnect. All right but what we have to talk about here is that there are a lot of major jazz artists that play by ear. Stan Getz.

MR: Lester Young.

RV: Stan Getz played by ear. Chet Baker played by ear. Okay? Chet Baker played by ear. I want to say Nat Adderley played by ear. CT — Clark Terry — played by ear. He worked all of his stuff out. Maynard Ferguson, now people might go naa, but Maynard Ferg — baloney. Listen to the early recordings of Maynard 'cause Maynard could play some bebop. Okay? Maynard, he had F's above double high C louder than anybody in the business but, and he told this to Art Falbush who teaches at Oneonta, SUNY Oneonta,

play by ear. And he interviewed a bunch of people. And Maynard was one of them. And so Maynard told Art, he said the biggest mistake I did was that Dizzy asked me to come to his house so we could work on some harmony, work on some piano stuff. He goes that was the biggest mistake I did that I didn't follow Dizzy's advice. But he goes, but what I did learn was that if I wasn't going to do that the ear had to be king. In other words your ears have got to be right. You've got to be able to know when you're not doing it right.

MR: How do you make them right?

RV: By knowing, by having the amount of information in your head of what sounds right and what doesn't sound right in the bebop tradition. Or even the blues. Understand something, up until the — I would say the inception of jazz, if you want to talk about it from 1917, if you want to talk about the Original Dixieland Jazz Band, but baloney. If we want to talk about ragtime music and improvised music coming out of New Orleans, up until even up to the 60s, by-and-large most of the music, the improvisations were informed by the melodies as opposed to all of these chord progressions, the melodies. Steve Wilson, I was over at DePaul University working with some students over there but Steve Wilson, a great saxophonist came in and gave a master class that was awesome. And he talks about when he first came to New York that he came to a jam session with all of the older cats from the Ellington — older cats — survivors that had played with Duke's band. And he asked them, he says, so tell me something — because he wanted to know how Duke worked with the musicians. And the cats told him, the cats told him that Duke would like sometimes write the person's name on the chart. So then Steve then asked them well when it came to soloing how did Duke write out the chord changes. And the answer was, "Chord changes!" They said no you have to listen to whatever the melody was and you have to figure that out from that. So they weren't sitting down looking at like minor 2-5s. The melody informed the improvisation. So you had to know the melody. And all those great, great, great solos from, from, from the swing era, those solos were — people understood, they understood the melodies. Now of course you have geniuses like Coleman Hawkins who's going to do what he did like "Body and Soul" where he starts introducing basically sheets of sound and that whole other approach of stuff. Now was he playing by ear? Did he have great ears? I don't know. I don't know if he was understanding the chord progressions. I know that he was definitely looking to something a little bit different. I know Dizzy played with him so a lot of cats went forward and started to try some other things. But I think it was Bird that was talking about this, through some friends of mine that dealt with Bird, some friends of mine from Seattle that are already gone but that knew Bird and how Bird told them I had to learn how to play all of these different things, whether it was the blues, "Rhythm" changes,

we're just playing by ear. They're playing by ear. I mean they understand the chord changes most definitely. And I think it's important for us to learn it, but in the event of a person who's learning it by ear how do I explain how Stan Getz can play on all of those Chick Corea tunes on that recording "Captain Marvel" when he didn't know how to read chord changes. And you could hear it, you could hear. Sometimes he deals with things in a certain way. Same thing with Chet Baker. I mean all of those recordings of "Have You Met Miss Jones" by Chet Baker, they're not really good. I've got to tell you something, because Chet always took that bridge that has like those Giant Stepy kind of things. And he never got it right. He never got it right. So you know, I'm sorry, and I love Chet mind you. My record collection, I have a lot of Woody and, as far as trumpets, Woody and Freddie and Dizzy. But man I got tons of Chet because there was something special about Chet. I loved Chet, Blue Mitchell, Art Farmer. I like the cats that played the pretty stuff. I like Donald Byrd. I like those cats. They play real pretty.

MR: You know I have to insert because I've often asked improvisers about what constitutes a wrong note and most people say there is no wrong note. But you just pointed out something, like Chet never really made the bridge.

RV: He didn't make the bridge man, I'm sorry. And people are going to hear this and go, "Ray, you're talking hay." No this is coming from somebody that absolutely adored Chet Baker's playing. I will admit that when I saw "Let's Get Lost" the movie, I had a difficult time listening to Chet's music for about three years. Because it gave such insight into his personality which for me was like wow this cat was not cool. Such beautiful music coming out of like such a — how shall I say —

MR: Flawed.

RV: Flawed individual. And he was a broken man. He was a broken man. He was broken. And so then my heart, as I get older, goes we are all flawed so don't judge, Ray. Don't judge. But I mean I just picked up some recording now, I believe it was in the Netherlands, two sessions of Chet Baker with a quartet in the studio. Beautiful. I buy a lot of Chet. My next dog is going to be called Chet. I'm just kidding. This is Ella by the way. Yes. But so, so the ear is going to let you know. Oh so, wait a minute — what constitutes a wrong note? Well understand something. You're a half step away from where you need to be. You're a half step away. You've got to know how to resolve what you're doing. You've got to resolve — but Monk, this is the whole thing — the way that jazz is being taught right now it's so mathematical and I could see it by the performances and the presentations by many of the talented young players that are coming up right now, where their presentation is basically flawless in the way that they execute, the way that they maneuver around chord progressions, the way that they're able to do all of that stuff is

not talking, man, this music is in constant morph so I have to respect whatever the next generation of kids are coming up with. It's all good. You know? I teach jazz history and — that's another dog here. Sorry folks. I teach jazz history and I talk about that. I go I'm not in love with everything about it but as a person who plays this music first and foremost, and I don't consider myself a jazz historian, I consider myself more like a jazz storyteller. You know I'll share stories. Because I hate, you know the historical end of it can get so boring and so my kids at the school at UVM kind of dig my approach 'cause I'm coming off from a place like let's listen to this.

MR: Yeah but the other thing is I think you're doing something that some of them don't have the opportunity in that you're playing things like you play at the Vermont Hotel is that correct?

RV: Every Wednesday at the Hotel Vermont. We've been doing that for ten years except for the little hiccup with Covid, but ten years of jazz.

MR: I think that kind of gig is so important for musicians because it's real life for God's sake and you learn to play, you learn to observe your audience that they're not twenty feet away in a whole row of chairs you know in this big auditorium —

RV: They're right in front of you.

MR: who are self-editing and I'm not sure what my point is but I feel a little sorry for the younger musicians because those gigs seem to be fewer and farther between these days.

RV: But this is something that I think — I talk to my students about — because last night it was great because yesterday I had a young man playing bass with me that's a student at the University. Because my two bass players were out of town, so I called this young man who's from the state, he's from Montpelier. And this is — he's going into his senior year now at UVM and I got him on the gig and I got him on because I figured great time, come on in, figure out what's going on, I kind of just guided him through what we were going to do. But these cats, what I do with these students is I don't just talk about what the music is — oh you've got to play these chord changes or rather try this scale on this thing. I also talk to them about please turn yourself around and speak to your audience. A lot of young cats are coming up right now and they've got this thing going on where they just play this-this-this-this-this. They don't even talk to the audience. They just play. And I'm like don't get me wrong, if it works for them fine. I came up playing with people like Tito Puente where Tito would just talk to the audience and they would laugh. I mean I don't know how many times I'd be in a gig with Dizzy — not playing with Dizzy but in the audience watching Dizzy and Dizzy had that audience in his hand. He talked to them. And it made them feel like they were in his living room. And he joked around with them and then when they played it was serious. So a lot of times I feel that something that's

here I went to see some of the young cats playing and I told them man the music that you're playing is the kind of music that you're going to have seven guys in the audience going, "Hey man wow, 'Giant Steps' in seven man, that's really hip man." And I would tell them yeah that's real cool but you know the average person on the street, they're not going to get it and they're not going to be there to listen to that. I think jazz in general has always been a people music but it's getting to the point where we're turning it into like something so far off and esoteric and cerebral that it no longer connects with people that are not necessarily musicians. You know? So we have to think about the audience and we could still play modern music that swings and is interesting but we don't — I think we're teaching the next generation of players to create something that is so self-absorbed that it doesn't connect to a wide audience. And mind you I mean the folks that come, I posted something on social media recently about — or I talked about it on a radio show — where I was hanging out with some of the folks that support jazz in this community and man, one cat man, this guy's got like 7,000 CDs in his house and he's got maybe 8, 900 LPs. And he's been to every concert. You name an important event in jazz in the last thirty, forty years, he's probably been to it and he's not a musician but he knows everybody on the recordings and his room was full of those kind of people. So there are people that are going to be able to sit there and go yeah, man, the real connoisseurs. But what do we do to be able to make the music so that those folks that come into the gig or might be just there and never heard this music, are going to come out going man that was beautiful, that was beautiful. I remember my girlfriend's mother, when we would go out to a gig she would always grab me and give me a kiss and she'd go, "Okay Raymond, go out there and play pretty for the people." I'll never forget that. And I think it's important to do that. And I am not sacrificing my art. I mean I listen to recordings of Cannonball Adderley talking to the audience. "Hey, how you doing?" And then he would come out and play, you know, something that was really — especially towards the end 'cause he was really pushing the envelope.

MR: He was "Hipadelphia."

RV: Yeah, yeah, yeah. I recently played with Roy McCurdy, his last drummer. I did a West Coast thing with him up the Pacific Northwest. We talked about all of that stuff. You connect with the audience. It's important that we do that. And that doesn't mean that we're not presenting art music because it is art music. But let them see the humanity of the musician on stage. Unless you are just so so so shy that you can't speak. I get it. But we don't talk to our students about that. I talk to my students about, because I have one group at school, it's called the Post Bop Ensemble. That's the name of the group. I would have never called it that. But what these guys do is they come in and I'll bring in some

that band like a band and I oversee the rehearsal. And these kids, first things first. Maybe one or two of them are music majors, the rest of them are engineers, astrophysicists, neuroscientists, all sorts of stuff. And these cats are on the case. We just graduated a young woman trombonist, an anthropology major. But she was a double major in music. So we got these kids that are coming in that are really brilliant but I have them develop the sets. And then when we're going to do a recital I tell them okay now we've got to tell our story. You just can't start and everything be at one level, you've got to go through peaks and valleys so the audience can really enjoy the complete presentation. Now where did I get that from? I got that from listening to records, from listening to albums. I remember working with Ray Barretto's band, this was Ray Barretto's jazz group New World Spirit and we'd go into the studio and then he'd want to come to the house, to my house with a bunch of different cassettes of different sequences of — and we would sit there and go man, no, let's try something different. And he would sit there with the cassette and go let's try something — 'cause it was so important for him as an artist to be able to tell the story of what he wanted to tell. And so since the audience in a situation like a recital doesn't have the power to hit shuffle, you have to tell them a story. You have to. So I talk to them about that and I always tell them, because there's a place in town that does jam sessions on Wednesday nights and they have jazz on Thursday, Friday and Saturday. And a lot of these kids get to go in there, and I tell them look at your audience man. Yeah you know what you want to play, and be prepared to play it, but look at the sequence of compositions, look at the sequence of compositions because you want to be able to tell that particular crowd what's going on. Like for instance yesterday we played, I forget what we started out the gig, but we started out the gig with whatever, I forget what it was. And we were going to go into Duke Ellington's "Azure" I think that's how you pronounce it. A-Z-U-R-E. But I knew that it wasn't the right thing. I said, "Na, na, na, let's switch it up immediately." I said, "Let's pull something else out and put it in its place." Because you've got to read the audience. You know that one, okay let's change the tempos around. It's important to do that because the music isn't just the notes it's the complete and total package. You know? And mind you be — what's the word — be sensitive to the audience too. You know, be sensitive.

MR: Let me ask you —

RV: That's just me. I'm not saying everybody's got to do it.

MR: No I'm totally onboard with that. I want to ask you about your compositions and your original music. If you — I was listening to "Sweet Love of Mine" and some things that are on your website. And I like the fact that when the song is over I can hum the melody back.

MR: Yeah.

RV: See Woody's the perfect example of that. Because Woody's music was harmonically very intellectual. He included rhythmic elements from Brazil and as well as Afro-Caribbean rhythms and swing. And when he soloed he was applying harmonic concepts that were not really that closely related to trumpet. They're mostly related to saxophone performance. But he played lyrically and beautiful even when he was playing his most abstract lines it was always beautiful. "Sweet Love of Mine" — beautiful composition. Woody could write beautiful melodies with very interesting chord progressions. He knew how to do it. To me Woody was one of the — Woody — I'm going to say something — Woody to me was the last great innovator of jazz trumpet in my opinion. Because he took what was there before, the schools of Louis Armstrong, Dizzy, Miles, of course he came out of a Freddie Hubbard bag. But the fact that he went into the direction applying the Coltrane things, applying the Eric Dolphy things, applying the things that he got from Larry Young, applying the things that he got from Joe Henderson. And he really changed the approach of how to play the trumpet. And I don't think anybody's come to — you know I could be wrong and there are so many talented — I'm not besmirching any of his contemporaries or any of the younger cats that have come out but he really did something different. I personally, I like the way Tim Hagans plays quite a bit. Because Tim comes out of that Woody thing but Tim's also got a kind of a different thing. And he plays beautiful. Tim's a good old friend of mine.

MR: What is it — you know Phil Woods said that he didn't consider himself an innovator, he was a craftsman. And maybe — I don't know how you look at your own playing but does it get harder as time goes by to become an innovator? To come up with something that's new?

RV: Something that's completely new? It's really difficult. We're in the age of — we're in the information age on a different level. So there's so many different things being thrown at us. How does one become an innovator? Well I would say learn as much of the history and gather from it and try to develop your own voice. At this point, like myself as an instrumentalist I just want to be able to tell the story. Hopefully I have my own sound. I'm very derivative of a lot of older people that came before me and I would say so. I mean yeah. I mean there's some things that I do definitely do that I've heard some other younger cats doing as well and I go oh okay, I think you've been listening to some of my records but I wouldn't call myself an innovator by any stretch of the imagination. I just think of myself as a person who wants to be able to play in a fashion that would be respectful to the people that I hold dear to this music — the Freddies, the Woodys, the Dizzys, the James Moodys, James Spaulding. These are people that I came into contact

stories which I can't share here because there's too much foul language in it. But it's all good — and it was all very positive stuff. But I take in whatever those people did and the things that I love from recordings by people like Donald Byrd and Art Farmer. And then of course I never really wanted to play trumpet. I wanted to play alto saxophone. And they didn't have them at the middle school — at the — well junior high school is what we called it back then. They didn't have them. They didn't have them. I started six months too late so instead of starting in September I started in the band program in January of 1974 so we're going on to fifty years of me trying to play the trumpet — coming up right now when this January comes up God willing. But all of this to say, I have a close affinity with saxophonists, especially tenor players. Now I just love the sound of that instrument, I love the voice out of it. So there's a lot of that in my head too just from all the tenor players that I've listened to. But I just think it's important to come from a place of immersing yourself in the sound and hoping to create a statement. If it's innovative fine. If it's not innovative and it's — how shall I say — it sounds as if it's coming out of a lot of different people that's okay too. It takes a long time to be able to develop kind of whatever you feel most comfortable with. You know I'm not one that likes to play things at super fast tempos.

MR: I'll tell you one thing I like about your sound and your improvising is that your articulation is very strong and you never mumble.

RV: Oh I have. And I like the mumblers. I like some of the guys you know but my thing is like again, just try to make the statement, try to be — I have a friend up here, Marty Fogel, he's the saxophone player that moved up to Vermont. He's from the New York area. And he played with folks as diverse as like Lou Reed and Don Cherry. But he's my senior by several years but he tells me, "Tell the truth and tell a story." Those are his two things. Tell the truth and tell the story. And I like that. I like that. That works for me you know. And I'm real open to like I mentioned to you a lot of maybe what would be considered like the hard boppers and stuff like that. But I listen to a lot of different types — I listen to the more avant garde stuff, I'm listening to a lot of Muhal Richard Abrams out of Chicago, the AACM. Folks like Don Cherry of course, I'm getting into Anthony Braxton in my old age right now, listening to a lot of those recordings, listening to — I'm really interesting in hearing that stuff. And I don't think I could play the more far out stuff but I'm finding myself sitting there like being pulled into this stuff and going this is really quite interesting. So I'm not just one of these guys that wants to play the "Rhythm" changes and bebop and the blues, I kind of like the more adventurous kind of things. And then I like pop music as well, you know what I'm saying? I don't have a problem hearing — I don't have a problem hearing a recording of Herb Alpert — I grew up with that

MR: As did I.

RV: Yeah, you know I don't have a problem. I'm not such a music — what's the word — snob. Oh it's got to be this. No. I see there's purposes and — purposes for a lot of things. You know Tom Brown who played the funky trumpet from Jamaica Queens back in the late 70s, early 80s. I like those records. It's all good. Because it has a purpose and there's an audience for that.

MR: You try to tell your students about — well I'll rephrase — is there anything on the bandstand that will aggravate you?

RV: Yes. Talking on stage. Don't talk on stage number one. Like the guy starts talking — you're on a gig could you like not do that? That's number one. Number two — talking on stage is a drag and talking between tunes is a major no-no. Like these kids will say, "Yeah I'm going to be playing at such-and-such a place, come out and see me." So folks come out and they're there and they play. They don't come prepared. They don't know what they're going to play beforehand. They start calling tunes at that very moment. And this is a working group. "Let's do this." "Oh do you have that chart?" "Yeah." No. Everything's got to be — people are out, go from one thing to another. My thing is like have the music out, you finish, go to the next one. Don't waste time. If there's more than 30 seconds between tunes you're wasting everybody's time. You should be ready. You should be ready. So my thing is like I was trying out a new bass player yesterday so I told him, "Just get there a little early so that I could kind of get you into what we're doing." So I got there, I had music for him. "Here's the charts." I told him what the sequence of the tunes were. I might make a change but I told him always keep your music so you could make a quick change. It's all good. It's all good. Because the audience doesn't want that. Hell no. The audience wants to go from one thing to another unless you're going to speak to the audience. "Hi, how are you? Welcome. This is such-and-such." But the musicians talking to each other, na. Another thing that's a big no-no for me is a musician walking up on stage and deciding before they play that it's time to warm up on stage. No. That's a no-no. People don't need to hear that shit. Sorry. You could take that out. They don't need to hear that crap. Go to a stairway or something and do that. I don't want to hear that. I don't want to hear it. They don't want to hear it. So you know respect your audience and don't show up looking like a schlump. Don't show up — I'm in New York so I'm going to say that. You know? Don't look like a schlump. Go in there, you know, and you know don't let the audience be better dressed than you are.

MR: You're defining what it is to be a professional.

RV: Yeah. I mean listen, when I was in New York City, because I live in Vermont right now. I moved from Vermont to New York City when I was 46 years old. 46?

RV: I mean from New York to Vermont. I'm in Vermont right now, I've been here 15 years. So I was like 46, 47 years old. Before I came up here I had to earn a living in New York City doing a wide variety of things: recording sessions, jingle dates of you don't know what the hell it's going to be but they don't send you the music in advance and they don't give you — now people have jingle dates they've got to call you three days — three or four days — a month in advance. "Oh I've got a jingle date then." In the old days it was like you got the call the night before 'cause the producer was just finishing maybe the rhythm tracks or something like that. Arturo O'Farrill used to get me, he was a contractor, and he used to get me on studio dates with his father. I can't thank Arturo enough for that. But I would go in there and there would be a studio orchestra in the studio while Chico O'Farrill conducted it and we would run it, boom, in and out. We'd run it one time and at the time I think he was listening to a click track but he had the — he would see the screen where he was and he would conduct against it. And he'd go, "Okay let's have a run through. One-two — " and we'd run it. "Okay let's record it. Thank you very much everybody." And you couldn't do that, "Oh I made a mistake." No, no, no, no, no, no, no. You've got to be really, really, really prepared to go there. And I'm not saying that I was the top studio guy, hell no. But I sat there — if I walked in there and I saw Victor Paz, I would walk in and see Victor Paz on trumpet, Earl Gardner, Jimmy — what do you call that — Eddie Bert on trombone. Come on man, I'm going to go in there and start screwing around?

MR: You're not going to be talking either.

RV: No. You've got to go in there and get — so I was doing that, I was doing contemporary classical music — like I traveled around the world with — one of the last projects I did was with Osvaldo Golijov. He's a conductor of contemporary classical music from Argentina. He's a composer rather, of contemporary classical music from Argentina. We traveled all over the world. And I wasn't playing bebop on that. I was playing C trumpet, piccolo trumpet and B flat trumpet in this work that he had. Right? Again was I playing "spang-a-lang"? No. But guess what. I was doing what I needed to do because I had a wife and three kids and mortgage payments and needed to get paid. And I wasn't going to sit there going, "Man you know I want to play my music." No, no, no, no, no, no, no. I was not — I did not come up with a trust fund where my parents had some money set aside for me so that I can move to New York and be creative and move to an apartment in the West Village that they're paying the rent for while I try to discover who I am. No. No, no, no, no, no, no. This was about work. So I did everything from weddings, salsa gigs, big band gigs, dance bands. You've got to do whatever you can. I don't know how many times this is my life: play Sunday — Saturday night with a salsa band but

sunrise service and you've got to go in there and play "The Trumpet Shall Sound" and Handel's "Messiah" on D trumpet. Okay, get ready, and you're going to go there with your puffy salsa chops going in there. And was I doing it because I necessarily wanted it? I was proud of my skill set and I would do it, but my endorphins were not going woo this is awesome. This is about I have to pay my bills. You know? So I often tell my students when I first started to break in like the salsa music scene man I was not the best player by any stretch of the imagination. But what I was was the guy who got there early and asked the band leader, "What time is the gig tomorrow, oh okay." And I'll get to the gig early. "What are we wearing?" The black suit. Okay wear the black suit, show up, don't bug the lead trumpet player with ten thousand questions about how to play the music, sit there, shut up, listen to the lead trumpet player, follow that person from here to eternity, get the job done. Because I needed to work. Did I want to be out there playing other kinds of things? Of course I did. You know? Thank goodness that Mongo Santamaria in 1987 gave me the opportunity to join his band and then that introduced me to a whole world of like jazz clubs and going out for a month and a half in the United States, going to Europe for European tours. So that opened me up to a whole different circle of players and gigs etcetera. But I learned from that. It wasn't like — oh I'm on Mongo's band, all I'm going to do is play creative music. No. And also another thing is this, before I started to teach I would always have a side hustle whether it was working at a preschool, working at a middle school, and they would always understand mind you — I've got to keep this one quiet here.

MR: You've got a duet now.

RV: They would always understand, oh Ray needs to go out of town. So I worked at a preschool, a Jewish preschool in Manhattan, and do all my preschool work there, and still do gigs with salsa bands around town and do all of the types of work that I do, and let them know I have to go on a West Coast tour with Mongo, I'll be out for a month and a half. "No problem Ray, everything's fine." So I always worked a side hustle because even when I was working, when I would come off from a month on the road I would always line up tons of salsa work. Because there was so much work to be had. And of course the salsa bands were a great way to generate income. It was also I would do wedding bands, I would do all of this kind of stuff and never like oh I'm above this, I'm a creative — I didn't talk any of that stuff because I needed to work. But I came up in that kind of generation you know. The working papers in New York State are 14 years old it's legal. But I came up in a household where like my father would look at me like, "Hey your brother's twelve years old — when he was twelve years old he was out shining shoes on 149th Street. So it was always a thing of like work to survive. So I always

private banking at the Banker's Trust Company of New York and at the time that I was at Banker's Trust I was still studying with Lonnie Hillyer, studying with Henry Novak, and etcetera, etcetera doing that stuff. And still doing like R&B gigs and salsa gigs. But I hated the job and in 1985 I just left private banking and I started to play music full time. And again my schedule blew up. And I started to work like there was no tomorrow because there was so much work in town. And I wasn't sitting there going oh man come on now, another salsa gig. I was just like going I have to earn a living.

MR: Well speaking of survival, let me wrap up with a question about, you know everybody's life has ups and downs. Is there something that has sustained you during the low periods in your life?

RV: Well you have to really love what you're doing. You've got to love what you're doing. And my wife has always been very supportive of me so like when I left private banking she was like, "Good, I'm glad you're leaving." Most wives would go, "You bum, what are you doing?" So she was supportive of it. Yeah. I have a supportive family. Look I have two sons that are — I have two adult sons with autism that I have to — that I am their guardian. So that keeps me on track of what I need to do to take care of business. I have to take care of business. At 62 years old I still have to be concerned with taking care of business. I have a spiritual faith system that I'm tied into. Unless folks want to talk to me about it, other than that I just kind of keep it quiet but I believe in the Lord Jesus Christ as the savior of my soul, and he has sustained me through cancer with my son Aaron and through — you know 80 percent of families with parents with autistic kids wind up getting divorced because the stress is just on a whole different level. But so you've got to learn to laugh. But as far as what gets me through it I tell my students unless you really love this, if you really want to do this for a living — because I have conversations with them like hey making a living in this is really difficult. It doesn't mean you shouldn't do it but what you should do is, as a young person they need to learn all the technology, all the computer stuff, how to record, how to do sessions at home and all that. Because the nature of the business has changed. Nobody is hiring — the whole idea of — I laugh now because people post on social media oh I'm going on a European tour. "How long were you out for?" "Four days." I'm like going come on man. Man I remember those gigs seven weeks on the road. I would take two suitcases with me because it was rough. You had to take — yeah I remember that. And it wasn't easy. You know so those things are not really in existence anymore. You know that doesn't really exist. There is not an Art Blakey out here hiring the next set of young cats to go out and play. Sadly it's not happening. I think that's sad. So I think many of my contemporaries who are older have somewhat dropped the ball because they chose to play with their

Maynard Ferguson or an Art Blakey or Horace Silver etcetera. Betty Carter you know. She was out there taking the young bloods and going okay I'm going to teach you about this. So that's not really happening, but the nature of the business has changed so much. There is no record recording industry. Anybody and their mother can record. Anybody can put their stuff on social media and become a sensation and never have paid any dues.

MR: Well this has been a very upbeat chat, Ray.

RV: Yeah, man. And I'm a happy person. Some folks might perceive some of the things that I say as like oh he's just dark. No, no, no. no. I love the music and I love to watch — I'll tell you something I enjoy being in the moment of discovery when I'm playing but to watch my students have a moment of discovery in their lessons or on the bandstand when I'm playing with them, that's worth a million dollars. I had a student in my class, my jazz trumpet student, and he put the horn down and he started to cry. And I went, "What's happening, man?" He says, "I didn't know I could do that." I went, "Well you just did it." He played through something like "Lady Bird" or something, which is the most — you know I gave him some concepts of how to play through it with rhythm and stuff like that and he played a nice solo on it. I went, "You played all the changes." And he was like, "I didn't know I could do this." I went, "Yeah." I said, "You're a human being just like I am." So yeah. Anyway I love all of the — I'm not a hater or anything and when I talk about the young generation of players coming up, they're going to have to figure it out. Then again maybe I have to figure out what the new thing is because it's completely changed. It's all about — it's about media presence and putting all sorts of stuff on line on a daily — content creation. That seems to be the way that people get record deals and — what's the word, tours etcetera without having paid any dues with an older musician that's going to tell them — excuse the French — "Yo that's some sad shit, you're not doing that here." Okay?

MR: Well said.

RV: I got that from Ray Barretto, from Mongo, from Tito Puente, oh my God, they read me the riot act. It wasn't going to be a walk in the park. And from all the — my thing was learn from the bandleaders. Shut your mouth and learn from the older cats. Because they're there. You know? So I don't know — how did this one go? You know? Next time we have to have all three dogs. So this is Mitzy and then this is Ella.

MR: And Ella.

RV: And Dizzy's floating around somewhere.

MR: Dizzy's floating around somewhere.

RV: Floating around. But I had to pick them up because they were making too much noise.

MR: Dizzy was good at floating around, wasn't he?

RV: Yeah, yeah, yeah he was okay. I think he's sleeping on the sofa. Yeah if there are any questions just let me know.

MR: Okay. We'll pause this and we'll say our good-byes.

RV: Thank you. Bye-bye now. All righty.